but they reject the concept of a god or supreme creator. If *pakavan* refers to a non-human deity then the *Tolkappiyam* could not have been the work of a Jain.

19 George L. Hart and Hank Heifetz, *Four Hundred Songs of War and Wisdom: an Anthology of Poems from Classical Tamil, the Purananuru*, 1999.

20 Robert Caldwell, *A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages*, 1856.

21 Not to be confused with either the pioneer Tamil scholar and collector of manuscripts U. V. Swaminatha Iyer or the well-known Dewan of Travancore State V. S. Subrahmanya Iyer.

22 Iravatham Mahadevan, *Early Tamil Epigraphy, from the Earliest Times to the Sixth Century B.C*, 2003.

23 Iravatham Mahadevan interviewed by T. S. Subramanian for *The Hindu* newspaper's magazine *Frontline*, 4 July 2009.

## CHAPTER 5: BUDDHISTS AND ROCK-CUT CAVES

1 My own view is that Chanakya's *Arthashastra* would have been among the first documents to be written in Brahmi, since it was an entirely secular work and Chanakya was ideally placed to get it done.

2 K. Rajan and V. P. Yatheeskumar, 'New evidences on scientific dates from Brahmi script as revealed from Porunthal and Kodumanal excavations', *Pragdhara,* 21-22, 2013.

3 Most recently, Nayanjot Lahiri, *Ashoka in Ancient India*, 2015.

4 Sharada Srinivasa and Srinivasa Ranganathan, *India's Legendary Wootz Steel: An Advanced Material of the Ancient World*, 2004.

5 The word dharma, which Ashoka used repeatedly in all his inscriptions, had its origins in the Vedas, where it stood for the cosmic laws underpinning the universe and